

The Dance School Awards: Industry Award - Dance School of the Year

Dance School of the Year Application / Nomination Questions.

Please find below 5 questions which we will need you to answer to proceed with your nomination.

Judges will consider:

- Clear, specific achievements from the past year and why they matter.
- Evidence of positive impact on students, staff, or the wider community.
- A clearly articulated ethos and set of values.
- Thoughtful support for students with different goals and pathways.
- Clear safeguarding procedures embedded in everyday practice.
- Awareness of student wellbeing and duty of care.
- Evidence of commitment to equity, diversity, and inclusion in policies, practice, and culture.
- Strong leadership and professional standards.
- A compelling overall case for why the school stands out.

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Wells Cathedral School

1. Tell us 3 things you are you most proud of your school achieving in the last year. *

1. Establishing dance as a central part of school life

Dance has become one of the most vibrant and visible aspects of creative life at Wells Cathedral School. Alongside weekly curriculum lessons, co-curricular classes and Dance Companies, our students perform dance in annual musicals, plays, symphony concerts and large-scale original dance productions presented in professional theatre settings.

Each year we create an original narrative dance production inspired by well-known stories, giving students the opportunity to experience the full creative process from rehearsal to performance. Recent productions include Steps in Snow (inspired by The Lion, the Witch and the Wardrobe), Sanctuary (based on The Hunchback of Notre Dame) and Don't Turn Back, our contemporary interpretation of Orpheus and Eurydice. These productions bring together pupils from across the school, are consistently performed to sold-out audiences, and provide exceptional artistic and performance opportunities that build confidence, creativity and collaboration.

2. Transforming our dance programme into a thriving community

Participation in dance has increased by 400%, growing from just 10 dancers to over 50 students regularly participating in Dance Companies, classes, examinations, competitions and productions. Alongside this growth, our competitive Dance Team has developed from a small group of enthusiastic dancers into an award-winning team, regularly achieving success at regional competitions. More importantly, dance has become a welcoming community where students of all ages, backgrounds and levels of experience feel they belong. This sustained growth reflects both the quality of our provision and the increasingly important role dance now plays within the wider life of the school.

3. Enabling every student to achieve their own definition of success

We are proud to provide outstanding opportunities for every dancer, whether they participate for enjoyment or aspire to professional training.

Students benefit from Rambert Grades Contemporary examinations, consistently achieving Merit and Distinction results, alongside extensive training in contemporary, ballet, jazz, tap, lyrical, commercial and musical theatre. At the same time, students who simply love to dance are able to perform regularly without the pressure of examinations or competition, developing confidence, creativity and lifelong enjoyment of the art form.

We are equally proud of the number of students progressing to leading conservatoires and vocational dance institutions through personalised audition preparation and individual mentoring. Our greatest achievement, however, is ensuring that every student leaves our department more confident, resilient and inspired than when they joined, regardless of the pathway they choose.

2. How would you describe your school's ethos and values? *

The ethos of Wells Cathedral School is "Be What You Are." It celebrates individuality, encourages students to pursue their passions, and places equal importance on personal growth, wellbeing and academic achievement.

Within the Dance Department, this philosophy underpins everything we do. We have created a welcoming, inclusive environment where every student is valued, regardless of previous experience, background or future ambition. We actively remove barriers to participation, ensuring dance is accessible to all students, from those taking their very first class to those preparing for professional careers.

Our department is often described as a family. Students work collaboratively across year groups, naturally mentoring younger dancers, forming lasting friendships and supporting one another through rehearsals, performances and competitions. Dance becomes far more than an extracurricular activity; it provides a creative outlet, a sense of belonging and a community where students feel safe to express themselves, challenge themselves and grow both as performers and as individuals.

3. How do you support both recreational and aspiring professional students? *

Every student has a place within our Dance Department, regardless of their starting point or future ambitions. We offer a wide range of opportunities, including curriculum lessons, co-curricular classes, private tuition, small group coaching, Dance Companies, examination classes and performance opportunities, allowing every student to engage at a level that suits their interests and aspirations. For recreational dancers, the emphasis is on enjoyment, creativity, confidence and participation. Students perform regularly in school productions, musicals, concerts and dance showcases without the pressure of examinations or competition, ensuring dance remains a positive and enriching experience. For aspiring professionals, we provide a structured pathway including advanced technical training, Rambert Grades Contemporary examinations, competitive performance opportunities and tailored audition preparation. Students receive personalised guidance throughout vocational and higher education applications, with many progressing to leading conservatoires (in the most recent year) including Northern School of Contemporary Dance, Rambert School, Rose Bruford, Urdang, Guildford School of Acting, London Studio Centre and Tring Park.

One example that reflects our philosophy is former student Alfie Stevens, who joined Wells with no previous dance experience. Through personalised coaching, performance opportunities and individual mentoring, he progressed rapidly and, within just sixteen months, received offers from every major contemporary dance conservatoire he auditioned for, including Rambert, Northern School of Contemporary Dance, Trinity Laban and The Place. He is now in his second year at Rambert, demonstrating the transformative impact of high-quality teaching combined with individual support.

4. What does safe guarding and student wellbeing look like in practice at your school? *

Student wellbeing and safeguarding underpin every aspect of our Dance Department. All teaching takes place within Wells Cathedral School's established safeguarding framework, with dance staff working closely alongside tutors, pastoral teams and families to ensure every student is supported both emotionally and physically.

We recognise that dance can be demanding, so we prioritise creating an environment where students feel safe, respected and able to thrive. Classes are built on trust, encouragement and mutual respect, enabling students to express themselves creatively while knowing they are supported throughout their training.

Staff maintain open communication with students, parents and colleagues, allowing concerns relating to wellbeing, workload or injury to be identified early and appropriate support put in place. Training is adapted where necessary to promote healthy physical development, and students are encouraged to celebrate personal progress rather than comparison with others.

Our older students naturally mentor younger dancers through Dance Companies and productions, helping to foster an inclusive culture where everyone feels welcomed and valued. By balancing high artistic expectations with genuine care for every individual, we ensure students develop not only as performers, but also as confident and compassionate young people.

5. Why do you believe your school deserves this award? *

Wells Cathedral School deserves this award because our Dance Department has become a truly exceptional programme that combines artistic excellence with inclusion, opportunity and outstanding pastoral care.

We have grown from a small extracurricular activity into a thriving community and one of the defining features of creative life at the school. Our students perform in ambitious original productions, achieve outstanding Rambert examination results, compete successfully at regional competitions and progress to some of the UK's leading vocational dance institutions.

What truly distinguishes our department, however, is our belief that every student matters equally.

Whether a young person joins us simply to experience the joy of dancing with friends or aspires to a professional career, they are welcomed, challenged and celebrated for who they are. We provide exceptional opportunities while remaining firmly committed to wellbeing and individual growth.

Our greatest achievement is not the awards our students win or the destinations they reach, it is that every young person who walks through our studio doors feels seen, supported, inspired and empowered to become the very best version of themselves. That commitment to excellence, opportunity and genuine care perfectly reflects the school's ethos of "Be What You Are" and is what makes Wells Cathedral School's Dance Department truly deserving of this recognition.

The greatest measure of our success is the impact our Dance Department has on the young people we teach. Their words speak more powerfully than we ever could:

"For a school that doesn't specialise in dance, the standard of the teaching, facilities and opportunities is exceptional. It's something you simply wouldn't find at any other school in this area."

"Dance at Wells has created a space where I feel safe, seen and free to express every part of myself, especially during the times when I didn't know how to do that anywhere else."

"Dance at Wells has literally changed the trajectory of my life. Without your belief in me and your guidance, I would never have had the confidence to audition for dance school, let alone gain a place. Dance lessons are honestly the best part of my day."

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